

Toward an improved conceptual understanding of consumer ambivalence

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Abstract Despite the significance of ambivalence in consumer research, the concept suffers from a lack of clarity. This study thus aims to develop an improved conceptual understanding of consumer ambivalence based on the analysis of existing definitions. A number of challenges are observed and addressed through key premises that characterize the concept of consumer ambivalence. Furthermore, the presented conceptualization is contextualized into the area of consumption. The result of this process is an enhanced view of consumer ambivalence that builds on and extends earlier conceptualizations in 1) recognizing a wide variety of concepts that can be studied under the umbrella of consumer ambivalence, 2) specifying the multitude of objects of consumer ambivalence, and 3) specifying the temporal scope of consumer ambivalence through the concept of consumption episodes. The proposed conceptualization accommodates the richness of different approaches to consumer ambivalence and thus contributes to a wide range of consumer research.

Keywords Ambivalence · Mixed emotions · Consumer · Conceptual development

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Ambivalence, which refers to the simultaneous positivity and negativity of a psychological concept, such as the attitude toward an object, has become a focal concept in consumer research over the past two decades. Ambivalence has enabled consumer researchers to gain novel insights into different decisions (Bee and Madrigal 2013; Roster and Richins 2009), choices (Jewell et al. 2002), satisfaction, and loyalty (Olsen et al. 2005), to name a few examples. Because of its potential to enhance the understanding of various consumption-related issues, ambivalence is a highly relevant concept in consumer research.

Although ambivalence has long been featured in fields such as psychology and sociology, it was not until 1997 that Otnes, Lowrey, and Shrum introduced the discussion on *consumer ambivalence* as a separate concept. In their conclusions, they stated that the challenge of fully articulating consumer ambivalence rests on future researchers who aim to deepen understanding of the concept. Indeed, ambivalence has been of increasing interest in consumer research since the 1990s. However, what ambivalence means in consumer research remains unclear. A wide variety of definitions represent various theoretical and empirical standpoints, which individual authors have unsystematically modified to suit their specific research questions. Many of these definitions include issues such as vagueness and an interchangeable use of concepts, which make their unambiguous interpretation impossible. This is problematic because meaningful scientific inquiry depends on adequate definitions that clarify the meaning of concepts used in scientific theories (Teas and Palan 1997). Failure to adequately define concepts leads to validity issues, poor measurement, misguided suggestions about the relationships between concepts, and poor credibility of the research findings (MacKenzie 2003).

The first proposed definition for consumer ambivalence, based on sociological, cultural, and psychological ambivalence, states that consumer ambivalence is “the simultaneous

or sequential experience of multiple emotional states, as a result of the interaction between internal factors and external objects, people, institutions, and/or cultural phenomena in market oriented contexts that can have direct and/or indirect ramifications on prepurchase, purchase or postpurchase attitudes and behavior” (Otnes et al. 1997, p. 82–83). Although an important contribution, we demonstrate that this definition still lacks precision and does not correspond to the growing body of consumer research around ambivalence. Perhaps for these reasons, relatively few studies in consumer research have actually adopted (partially or completely) the definition of Otnes, Lowrey, and Shrum, with notable exceptions including Darmody and Bonsu (2007), Johnson and Grier (2012), Mileti et al. (2013), and Ruth et al. (2002). Thus, through an analysis of the definitions of ambivalence in the consumer context, we take stock of consumer ambivalence after two decades of research. We point out various challenges and suggest key premises on which to base an enhanced understanding of the concept. Therefore, the aim is to develop a more comprehensive conceptualization and framework to guide future research on consumer ambivalence.

Against this background, we contribute to consumer research on ambivalence by extending Otnes, Lowrey, and Shrum’s definition, as well as subsequent definitions, through three key premises that will be developed throughout this study: 1) Consumer ambivalence is a structural property of any evaluative psychological concept to which two valences can be assigned; 2) Consumer ambivalence is directed toward one clearly specified consumption-related object; and 3) Consumer ambivalence exists in consumption episodes. Through the first premise, we broaden the scope of consumer ambivalence, and thus enable its use by a wider audience of consumer researchers. Through the second and third premises, we address vagueness in existing definitions through a specification of the objects and temporal scope of consumer ambivalence. Furthermore, we contextualize the developed conceptualization into the domain of consumption by outlining how consumer ambivalence exists in both the internal, micro-level context of the consumer and in the wider socio-cultural context of consumption. Through this contextualization process, this study extends both major streams of consumer research (consumer psychology and consumer culture theory [CCT]) by bridging the gap between sociological and psychological ambivalence in consumer research. Finally, we present a synthesizing framework that enables a more accurate positioning of existing and future research on consumer ambivalence than what has previously been possible in this seemingly fragmented area.

Analysis of existing definitions

We continue with an analysis of existing definitions of ambivalence, which are categorized into three groups: attitudinal

ambivalence, mixed emotions, and definitions in CCT. For each category, we first review the origins of the concept in the psychological or sociological literature, followed by a review of how the concept has been applied to consumer research, based on a representative sample of 67 papers. The sample was collected following a systematic database search (the papers in the sample are marked with an asterisk* in the reference list). We then analyzed the identified definitions (cf. Hart 2005) and/or conceptualizations (cf. MacInnis 2011) to reach an understanding of what ambivalence is according to existing consumer research. We evaluated the definitions on four criteria, namely vagueness, definition through antecedents, interchangeable use of concepts, and correspondence with the etymological meaning of ambivalence, which were chosen to facilitate the analysis of major definitional issues. Doing so was considered a reasonable approach because to the best of our knowledge, this is the first attempt to critically evaluate the definitions of ambivalence in consumer literature. We will use this evaluation as a basis for the development of our conceptualization of consumer ambivalence toward the end of this paper. Before the analysis and evaluation of the definitions, we discuss each evaluation criterion in detail.

Evaluation criteria

The first criterion used to evaluate the definitions is *vagueness*, which means that a concept lacks clearly defined boundaries (Hampton 2007) and thus has several meanings that cannot be separated from one another (Strunz 2012). Vagueness is problematic because without conceptual precision, science cannot be separated from faith, and the applicability of concepts to empirical research cannot be evaluated; furthermore, empirical testability presupposes conceptual precision (Strunz 2012). Claiming certain knowledge of the world when the words used to express such knowledge are vague is impossible (Hampton 2007). We find three major sources of vagueness: the temporal scope of consumer ambivalence, the objects of consumer ambivalence, and, in the area of mixed emotions, the amount of emotions that the term “mixed emotions” includes. The second evaluation criterion is whether the concept is *defined through its antecedents*. Such a misspecification makes the empirical testing of the theoretical linkages between concepts and their antecedents impossible, since the relationships are assumed in the definition (MacKenzie 2003). The third evaluation criterion, namely the *interchangeable use of concepts*, was included because the concept of mixed emotions is sometimes used interchangeably with ambivalence (e.g., Hogg and Penz 2007), even though the concepts are not always interchangeable. The fourth and final evaluation criterion is correspondence with the *etymological meaning* of ambivalence. The term ambivalence comprises two literal components derived from Latin: *ambo*, which means “both,” and *valere*, which means

“to be strong” (Foy 1985). In the area of attitudes, valence has come to mean both positivity and negativity (Eagly and Chaiken 1993), so the “valere” component can be interpreted as both strength and positivity versus negativity. The evaluated definitions do not always follow this etymological meaning, which is problematic because etymology enables deriving a consensus about the use of words through an understanding of their meaning (Keil 2004). The following discussion covers the theoretical background of the different definitions and conceptualizations of ambivalence in consumer research and evaluates them by using the criteria outlined above. We use the evaluation as a basis for an improved conceptualization of consumer ambivalence.

Attitudinal ambivalence

In the following, we outline the origins of attitudinal ambivalence and analyze how it has been defined in consumer research. Attitudinal ambivalence appears to dominate the definitional field of ambivalence in consumer research, underlining the need to update the definition provided by Otnes et al. (1997), who defined the core of consumer ambivalence merely as “mixed or multiple emotions”. An attitude refers to “general and enduring favorable or unfavorable feelings about, evaluative categorizations of, and action predispositions toward stimuli” (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994, p. 401). The cognitive attitude component refers to beliefs and thoughts, whereas the affective component refers to emotions and feelings associated with an attitude object (Zanna and Rempel 1988). Attitudes are traditionally assumed to exist on a single valence dimension, which makes it impossible to tell whether a respondent claiming to be neutral is indifferent or ambivalent toward the attitude object (Kaplan 1972). Thus, attitudes were re-conceptualized as two-dimensional rather than bipolar (Thompson et al. 1995), providing a basis for research on attitudinal ambivalence in the consumer literature. Attitudinal ambivalence is operationalized in two ways: objective (also termed potential) ambivalence refers to the coexistence of both positive and negative evaluations, whereas subjective (also termed felt) ambivalence refers to the subjective experience of ambivalence (van Harreveld et al. 2009).

Table 1 lists representative examples of definitions of attitudinal ambivalence in consumer research. It has been defined as psychological conflict (Roster and Richins 2009) and also as evaluative activities, such as holding evaluations (Pang and Keh 2011) or expressing them (Olsen et al. 2005). Furthermore, the attitude structure is a key consideration because attitudes are summary evaluations consisting of various beliefs, emotions, and/or behaviors (Fazio 2007), and in many definitions, attitudinal ambivalence lies within the structure of these attitude components. Accordingly, attitudinal ambivalence has been defined as a property of attitudes (Jewell et al. 2002) or evaluations (Olsen et al. 2009), and according

to some of the definitions, ambivalence is *based on* feelings (Choi and Crandall 2008) or evaluations (Olsen et al. 2005). Finally, there are also definitions stating that ambivalence is an experience of contradiction (Honkanen and Olsen 2009), reflecting the subjective operationalization of ambivalence.

A closer look at the definitions shows vagueness in the use of the word “simultaneous,” such as in the following definition: “Ambivalence is a state of having simultaneous positive and negative cognitions and feelings towards the same object” (Tudoran et al. 2012, p. 393). Technically, simultaneity can be claimed only if two events or processes (for example beliefs, emotions, and/or behaviors) occur at exactly the same time (Jammer 2006). However, what if they occur sequentially but within a time frame of, say, five seconds? Would this still indicate ambivalence in attitudes? Within the same time window, is it possible at all to determine whether the valence components are simultaneous, especially with self-reports? Furthermore, attitudinal ambivalence has been defined either as a state (Moody et al. 2014) or, conversely, a process (Ou and Sia 2010). What, then, does simultaneity really mean with regard to ambivalence? These questions will be addressed from the perspective of consumption episodes (premise 3). Another example of vagueness is the word “object,” which can be any discriminable evaluated entity (Eagly and Chaiken 2007). Thus, reference to an object without further specification already in the operational definition is a major source of vagueness. Furthermore, the object has an important role in the consumption context because different types of ambivalence (i.e., cognitive or affective) might take place toward different objects (Conner and Sparks 2002). Definitions of ambivalence should therefore specify the object they refer to (premise 2).

Mixed emotions

In the following, we discuss the concept of mixed emotions. Originally, consumer ambivalence was defined as “mixed or multiple emotions” (Otnes et al. 1997, p. 82–83). Subsequently, a body of consumer research has studied mixed emotions by using attitudinal ambivalence as one literature stream around which hypotheses about and operationalizations of mixed emotions are built (Bee and Madrigal 2013), or as an interchangeable concept with mixed emotions (Kramer et al. 2008; Penz and Hogg 2011). The evaluative space model (ESM; Cacioppo and Berntson 1994) from the attitude literature had an especially important influence because it challenged the prevailing circumplex models of emotions, which suggested that happiness and sadness are mutually exclusive (e.g., Russell 1980). The model implies that the affect system is a bivariate space instead of a bipolar continuum, and thus allows the coactivation of positivity and negativity (Larsen et al. 2001). Consequently,

Table 1 Analysis of the definitions of attitudinal ambivalence: Illustrative examples

Attitudinal ambivalence is...	Attitudinal ambivalence is based on...	Example	Source
Conflict		"Ambivalent feelings represent a state of psychological conflict concerning an attitude object." (p. 48)	Roster and Richins (2009)
Property of an attitude		"(...) we conceptualize ambivalence as a component of an attitude that reflects the presence of positive and negative feelings or beliefs that are deemed important by the decision maker." (p. 334)	Jewell et al. (2002)
Property of evaluations		"People often hold inconsistent beliefs or feelings about an object or issue, some positive and some negative (Breckler, 1994). The evaluative inconsistency toward an attitude object is referred to as ambivalence (Katz 1981)." (p. 358)	Russell et al. (2011)
Evaluative activity		"(...) the activity of holding opposing evaluations about a single object (...)" (p. 51)	Pang and Keh (2011)
Experience of contradictions		"'Ambivalence' is one term used to describe contradictions people experience in their individual attitudes, beliefs or preferences (Thompson et al. 1995)" (p. 296)	Honkanen and Olsen (2009)
Evaluative process		"Ambivalence research theorizes that, even in the same relationship, individuals experience different encounters with different intentions, and these lead to different outcomes; therefore a relation often contains simultaneously positive and negative evaluative processes in individuals (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994)" (p. 914)	Ou and Sia (2010)
State		"Ambivalence, more specifically attitudinal ambivalence, is the state in which a person is inclined to assess equivalently strong positive and negative evaluations toward an attitude object (Thompson and Zanna 1995)" (p. 270)	Moody et al. (2014)
	Feelings	"(...) evaluations of Black models in ads are determined by a complex mix of positive and negative feelings characterized by ambivalence." (p. 724)	Choi and Crandall (2008)
	Evaluations	"(...) conflicting and inconsistent feelings may underlie the evaluation of a single object or that attitude evaluations are based on separate positive and negative evaluations of different attitude object components (Thompson et al. 1995)" (p. 249)	Olsen et al. (2005)

individuals can experience happiness and sadness at the same time.

Table 2 shows that mixed emotions are most commonly defined as the experience of two emotions (Lau-Gesk and Kramer 2005) or as opposing feeling states (Grasshoff and Williams 2005), which corresponds with the experience-based definition because the word "feeling" represents the experience component of emotions (Barrett et al. 2007). Thus, the predominant definition relates to experience, which is in line with the origins of research on mixed emotions in psychology. However, the emotions have been defined on different levels of abstraction. As Table 2 shows, the broadest level constitutes positive and negative valence (Hershfield and Adler 2012), which is conceptually similar to ambivalence. A slightly more concrete approach is to categorize specific emotions as hedonic (excitement and sadness) or self-conscious (pride and guilt) (Hung and Mukhopadhyay 2012). The most concrete and most common approach involves a pair of differently valenced emotions, predominantly happiness and sadness (e.g., McGraw and Lau-Gesk 2008). The research context tends to guide the choice of specific pairs of emotions; hope and fear are a more relevant combination in the case of anticipatory mixed emotions, for example (Bee and Madrigal 2013). Although research has predominantly focused on contrasting valence, mixed

emotions of the same valence have also been studied (Grasshoff and Williams 2005; Ruth et al. 2002).

In the area of mixed emotions, simultaneity and sequentiality are discussed more thoroughly than they are in the area of attitudinal ambivalence. Nevertheless, they remain a source of vagueness. Some authors have inferred mixed emotions through sequential manipulation of different emotions (Labroo and Ramanathan 2005), or through an electromyography measurement showing negative emotions immediately followed by positive emotions (van den Broek and Westerink 2009). However, disagreement exists on whether sequential mixed emotions are, in fact, mixed emotions, or merely a vacillation between two emotions (Larsen and McGraw 2011). The time period within which this vacillation could still be called mixed emotions is also an issue. Another source of vagueness is whether mixed emotions occur in pairs, causing confusion around the difference between mixed emotions and ambivalence. Mixed emotions have been defined as "multiple emotions" (van den Broek and Westerink 2009, p. 1062) or "blends of emotions" (Fournier and Alvarez 2013, p. 259), which could refer to more than two emotions. However, most papers defined or at least operationalized them in pairs (Table 2). These issues will be covered in premises 2 and 3.

Table 2 Analysis of the definitions of mixed emotions: Illustrative examples

Mixed emotions are...	Specific emotions addressed	Example	Source
An experience		"(...) we explore conditions under which consumers may react more favorably to a mixed emotional experience composed of particular positive and negative emotions than to a purely positive emotional experience." (p. 77)	Lau-Gesk and Kramer (2005)
Oppositional feeling states		"(...) recent studies have begun to investigate mixed emotions, shedding initial light on ways in which consumers cope with and respond to such oppositional feeling states" (p. 76)	Grasshoff and Williams (2005)
	Positive and negative emotions	"(...) the experience of mixed emotions – that is, the concurrent experience of positive and negative emotions (...)" (p. 278)	Hershfield and Adler (2012)
	Hedonic and self-conscious emotions	"(...) mixed emotional experience that elicits a positive (negative) hedonic emotion of excitement (sadness) and a negative (positive) self-conscious emotion of guilt (pride)." (p. 278)	Hung and Mukhopadhyay (2012)
	Two emotions of opposite valences	"The experience of oppositely-valenced emotions, referred herein as mixed emotions, include the happiness and sadness felt when one's child leaves home for college, the excitement and fear aroused when one rides a rollercoaster, or the anger and hope experienced when one protests war." (p. 112)	McGraw and Lau-Gesk (2008)
	Two emotions of the same valence	"The study of mixed emotions is receiving increasing attention in both psychology and consumer behavior. (...) However, this work so far has focused only on mixing positive and negative emotions together. It is possible, however, that consumers may often experience mixed emotions of the same valence, such as both fear and anger or both happiness and warmth." (p. 78)	Grasshoff and Williams (2005)

Ambivalence in consumer culture theory

Attitudinal ambivalence and mixed emotions represent a psychological and often quantitatively oriented approach toward consumer research, whereas a stream known as CCT concerns the "sociocultural, experiential, symbolic, and ideological aspects of consumption" (Arnould and Thompson 2005, p. 868). This stream involves a group of research domains labeled as consumer identity projects, marketplace cultures, socio-historic patterning of consumption, and mass-mediated marketplace ideologies and consumers' interpretive strategies (Arnould and Thompson 2005). Much of the understanding of ambivalence in CCT research is derived from sociology, and in the following, sociological ambivalence and the definitions of ambivalence used in the CCT stream are discussed. Broadly, sociological ambivalence refers to "incompatible normative expectations of attitudes, beliefs, and behavior assigned to a status (i.e., a social position) or to a set of statuses in the society" (Merton and Barber 1976, p. 6). More narrowly, it refers to "incompatible normative expectations incorporated in a *single* role or a *single* social status" (Merton and Barber 1976, p. 6, *italics in original*). According to Merton and Barber (1976), sociology concerns the processes through which social structures generate the circumstances in which ambivalence becomes embedded in statuses and roles. Therefore, sociological ambivalence can be seen as being based on social structures. Sociological ambivalence can be further divided into subcategories, such as the ambivalence

that is embedded in contradictory cultural values held by members of a society (Merton and Barber 1976).

As seen in the Table 3, the definition of sociological ambivalence has been synthesized with psychological ambivalence in the consumer context through the recognition that sociological ambivalence occurs at the social structural level of consumption, while psychological ambivalence occurs at the individual level (VOICE Group 2010). In another example, consumers may be ambivalent about their individual practices if they counter what is understood as normatively correct behavior (Connolly and Prothero 2008). Similarly, studies focusing on cultural ambivalence have recognized both psychological and cultural levels of ambivalence, and further specified cultural ambivalence as an antecedent of psychological ambivalence (Nelson and Otnes 2005). On the other hand, studies focusing on the individual level define ambivalence, for example, as mixed emotions (Wooten 2006), simultaneous resistance and reinforcement (Bonsu 2009), or coexisting positive and negative selves (Karanika and Hogg 2010). Furthermore, as is demonstrated by Table 3, many studies conceptualize ambivalence merely through its antecedents, which exist on the socio-cultural level of consumption.

Conceptual problems also exist in the CCT stream. To the extent that the definitions in the CCT stream have a psychological basis, the issue of temporal vagueness exists also in this area. Furthermore, the number and valence of emotions included in mixed emotions is unclear. In addition, many definitions indicate the antecedents of ambivalence without first

Table 3 Analysis of the definitions of ambivalence in CCT: Illustrative examples

Antecedents of ambivalence	Ambivalence is...	Example	Source
Not defined	Contradictory normative expectations (sociological level)/ Emotional, cognitive, or motivational contradictions (individual level)	“At the social structural level, sociological ambivalence has been viewed as contradictory normative expectations that occur in institutional resources and requirements (statuses, roles and norms). At the individual level, psychological ambivalence has been referred to as contradictions that are primarily subjective and evident in cognitions, emotions and motivation “(p. 377)	VOICE Group (2010)
Conflicting values, norms, traditions, and practices	Mixed emotions	“(…) the emergence of mixed or multiple emotions that arise from conflict among values, norms, traditions, and practices of different cultures not found within the same society” (p. 89–90)	Nelson and Otnes (2005)
Not defined	Tension between past and present (on the level of culture and/or individual experience)	“(…) a temporal ambivalence, a tension between past and present (...) The present is marked as an unsatisfactory place (...) The longed-for past, however, is marked as a place of satisfying plenitude (...) Again, the nostalgic experience is ambivalent. On the one hand, it plays out a narrative of loss (...) But at the same time it plays out a narrative, a fantasy, of recovery (...)” (p. 124)	Higson (2014)
Not defined	Resistance and reinforcement	“(…) ambivalence – their expressed resistance to the institutionalization of Africa as a subaltern subject and their unconscious reinforcement of colonial African imagery and vocabulary.” (p. 7)	Bonsu (2009)
Not defined	Both positive and negative selves	“The notions of the desired and undesired self, which are imagined selves (Markus and Nurius 1986) - that can be positive or negative - within identity projects.” (p. 1092)	Karanika and Hogg (2010)
Combining masculinity and femininity	Not defined	“(…) sexuality is expressed through combining qualities of the masculine (penetrative teeth) and the feminine (enveloping lips), thus generating a profound erotic ambivalence that destabilizes the representation of sexual roles.” (p. 29) “The ambivalence towards gender created by the notion of vampirism accordingly disrupts traditional delineations of gender roles.” (p. 33)	Goulding and Saren (2009)
Lack of understanding of “right” and “wrong”	Not defined	“Ambivalent, because of the general absence of clear-cut distinctions and certainties around what constitutes ‘right’ and ‘wrong’, ‘good’ or ‘bad’.” (p. 417)	Wicks et al. (2007)

defining it. Finally, the definitions do not always contain the elements of “both” and “valence,” and thus do not follow the etymological meaning of the word (for example, defining ambivalence as a conflict of masculinity and femininity [Goulding and Saren 2009]). These issues will be covered in the premises and the section in which we contextualize our proposed conceptualization into the area of consumption.

Summary of the definition analysis

Table 4 includes a summary of the definition analysis according to the key criteria identified at the beginning of this paper. Vagueness, in terms of the temporal scope of ambivalence, the object of ambivalence, and the number and valence of emotions included in the definition of mixed emotions, are evidently common problems. Furthermore, it is unclear how ambivalence is different from its antecedents. Some definitions have departed from the etymological meaning of the word, and to what extent they can still be called “ambivalence”

remains unclear. In Table 4, we present the corresponding premises to each definitional challenge to give an overview of how we address the challenges in our conceptualization of consumer ambivalence.

On the other hand, the existing definitions also involve positive and useful features, on which we can start to construct our conceptualization. As seen in Table 4, the challenges that we have discussed are not all found in each definition category. Many definitions of attitudinal ambivalence and mixed emotions involve clear statements of the definition of ambivalence, and do not have the problem of definition through antecedents. Apart from a few exceptions in the definitions of mixed emotions, these two categories also specify two opposing valences as a part of the definition, thus following the etymological meaning of ambivalence. For these reasons, we can use them to answer the key question of what consumer ambivalence is as we develop premise 1. Many of the definitions in CCT, on the other hand, provide valuable insight about the antecedents of ambivalence, and even though

antecedents do not belong to the core of definitions, they are extremely important to ambivalence in the context of consumption. The definitions that are especially useful integrate the individual and sociocultural levels of ambivalence (e.g. VOICE Group 2010; Nelson and Otnes 2005) because they serve as bridges between psychological approaches to ambivalence and the more socio-cultural approach used in the CCT literature. The rest of this study develops key premises and contextualizes ambivalence in the field of consumer research against this background.

Key premises and a redefinition of consumer ambivalence

This study thus far represents an attempt to formulate a comprehensive picture of ambivalence in consumer research through an analysis of existing definitions. We find that ambivalence has been given such a variety of meanings in consumer research that it has become an ambiguous concept. A number of definitional challenges (Table 4) need to be resolved before an improved conceptualization of consumer ambivalence can be formulated. Therefore, three premises that address three key questions are presented in response to definitional challenges: What is consumer ambivalence? (premise 1); What does it concern? (premise 2); When and how does it occur? (premise 3). The conceptualization developed through the premises is broad enough to accommodate the richness of approaches to ambivalence in consumer research. However, because of its broadness, the conceptualization requires each researcher to define the central elements of the study (i.e., the consumption episode and the object of ambivalence). Therefore, these central elements are also discussed to the extent that they have implications for the conceptualization of consumer ambivalence. Figure 1 illustrates the premises and serves as an organizing framework for the conceptualization developed in the following section.

Premise 1: Consumer ambivalence is a structural property of any evaluative psychological concept to which two valences can be assigned.

Premise 1 forms the core of consumer ambivalence, around which we begin the conceptualization process. In the following, we provide the argumentation for each component of this premise.

Structural property of any evaluative psychological concept

Etymologically, ambivalence could mean anything that has two valences, but attaching it to the term “consumer” also implies that it occurs *within* the consumer. Hence, only psychological concepts can have the property of ambivalence. This proposition is well-aligned with existing definitions in which the antecedents of ambivalence, especially in the CCT stream, tend to be external to the consumer, such as conflicting “values, norms, traditions, and practices” (Nelson and Otnes 2005, p. 90). However, in most cases, when ambivalence is defined separately from its antecedents, it is internal to the consumer, which is in line with the conceptualization of sociological ambivalence as a source of psychological ambivalence (Merton and Barber 1976).

Using psychological ambivalence as a starting point, we turn to the existing definitions of attitudinal ambivalence to define consumer ambivalence further. In this stream, ambivalence is predominantly defined through other evaluative psychological concepts, for example, as “evaluative inconsistency” (Lorenzon and Russell 2012, p. 59). Ambivalence has even been attached to a wider spectrum of evaluative psychological concepts such as trust and distrust (Moody et al. 2014; Ou and Sia 2010). Etymologically, ambivalence does not refer to any specific concept to which it should be assigned, which has enabled consumer researchers to generate important insights for a wide audience under the framework of ambivalence. Therefore, we advocate for an inclusive definition of consumer ambivalence. Accordingly,

Table 4 Summary of the definition analysis

Criterion	Attitudinal ambivalence	Mixed Emotions	Ambivalence in CCT	Corresponding premise(s)
Vagueness	1. Temporal scope 2. Objects of ambivalence	1. Temporal scope 2. Objects of ambivalence 3. Number of emotions in “mixed emotions”	1. Temporal scope 2. Number of emotions in “mixed emotions”	Premise 1 Premise 2 Premise 3
Definition through antecedents			Definitions only stating where ambivalence arises from	Premise 1
Interchangeable use of concepts		Mixed emotions used interchangeably with ambivalence	Mixed emotions used interchangeably with ambivalence	Premise 1
Etymology		Definitions of mixed emotions, which refer to emotions of the same valence	Definitions not always containing “both valences”	Premise 1

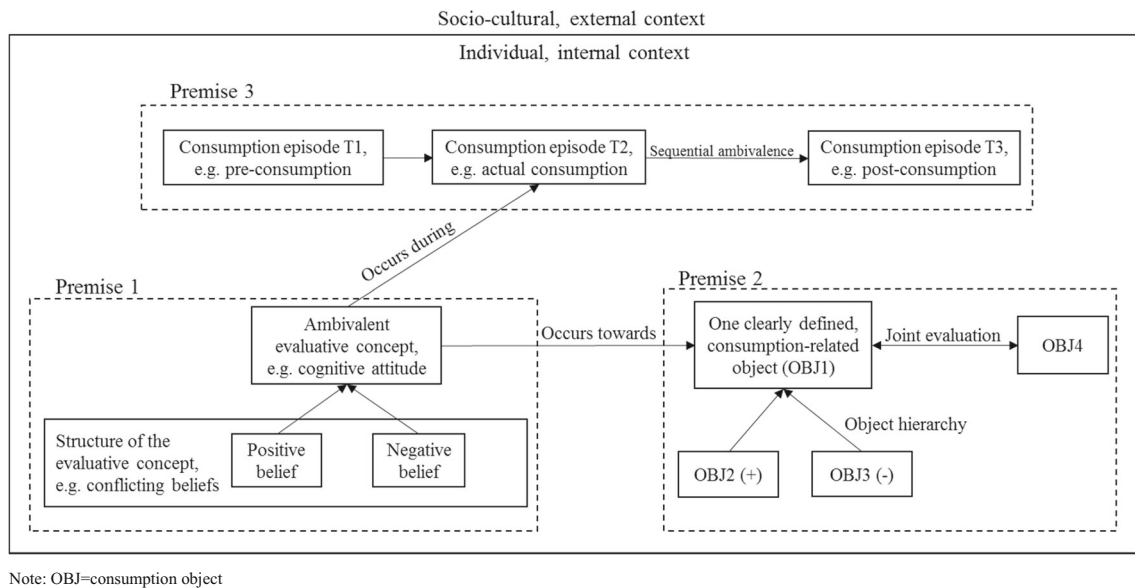


Fig. 1 Organizing framework of consumer ambivalence

we define the “evaluative psychological concept” broadly, ranging from affective evaluations to more cognitive judgments (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994; Fazio 1995). As an example, we demonstrate ambivalence in the cognitive attitude component in Fig. 1. However, a concept needs some precision to be useful for scientific inquiry (Strunz 2012), and the first boundary that we give to consumer ambivalence is specifying that it is a property of only evaluative concepts. This boundary implies that other consumer-related concepts such as personality traits are excluded from the scope of consumer ambivalence. In addition, we follow the existing literature in both psychology (Scott 1966) and consumer research (Jewell et al. 2002), in which ambivalence has been conceptualized as a property of evaluative concepts. This implies that ambivalence operates like an adjective that can be assigned to various evaluative concepts. As a further specification, ambivalence occurs in the structure of evaluative psychological concepts (Krosnick and Petty 1995). Therefore, we assume that an evaluation consists of components, which can involve emotions, beliefs, or previous behavioral experiences with the object (Fazio 1995), and ambivalence exists in this evaluative structure. We demonstrate this in Fig. 1, in which we use two conflicting beliefs as a simple example of ambivalence as a structural property of the focal cognitive attitude.

Two valences

Earlier, we discussed how valence originally meant “being strong” (Foy 1985), and how it carries both the meaning of positivity and negativity (Eagly and Chaiken 1993). Both aspects guide our definition of consumer ambivalence. By stating that ambivalence requires both positivity and negativity, we clarify its relationship to mixed emotions. Mixed emotions can be the

structural components that make up consumer ambivalence when studied from a dimensional perspective with the assumption of positivity and negativity. However, mixed emotions do not need to be both positive and negative. Cognitive appraisal theory assumes that emotions are associated with an individual’s appraisal of the environment along several cognitive dimensions besides positivity and negativity (Smith and Ellsworth 1985). This assumption implies that any emotions, including those of the same valence, can be mixed, and therefore the term “mixed” does not require opposing valences, as opposed to the term “ambivalence.” Hence, we argue that mixed emotions of the same valence do not correspond with ambivalence, and thus bring precision to Otnes et al.’s (1997) original definition of consumer ambivalence. An important reason why the concepts of ambivalence and mixed emotions should be separated is that emotions are a complex concept that varies along multiple dimensions besides valence (such as certainty and control) (Smith and Ellsworth 1985), implying that two emotions of the same valence can have different behavioral consequences (Lerner and Keltner 2000). By forcing mixed emotions to only mean “mixed” in terms of valence, we would exclude other key dimensions in which emotions can vary. Hence, we propose keeping the two concepts separate. However, a more detailed development of the concept of mixed emotions is outside of the scope of this paper.

Valence also means “being strong,” which has implications for the operationalization of objective ambivalence. Objective ambivalence traditionally presupposes a strength aspect: as the similarity in magnitude between the positive and negative components increases, the attitude becomes more ambivalent, and with similarity held constant, ambivalence increases directly with the intensity of the positive and negative components (Thompson et al. 1995). However, one component often

dominates the other, which means that an attitude is predominantly positive or negative, but nevertheless ambivalent (Priester and Petty 1996). This description does not appear to be in line with the etymological meaning of “both” and “being strong.” However, “strong” is a vague term and has received only arbitrary operationalizations in existing literature. For example, Maio et al. (1996) define the 33% of their participants with the lowest ambivalence scores as “not ambivalent.” However, such a limit is contingent upon the overall level of ambivalence among all of the participants. A more reasonable approach is to see ambivalence as a continuum. Thus, we argue that “being strong” should be defined through factors in the empirical context. For example, in some situations, even a small amount of negativity in a predominantly positive evaluation can entail meaningful ambivalence, or vice versa.¹

Premise 2: Consumer ambivalence has one clearly specified consumption-related object.

As visualized in Fig. 1, consumer ambivalence has an object. The object should be specified in the operational definition of each study because “object” is a vague term that can indicate a wide variety of things, including social issues, situations, categories of people, specific individuals, as well as physical objects (Fazio 1995). Hence, the premise includes the expression “clearly specified.” This premise again clarifies the boundaries of consumer ambivalence because psychological concepts, which are not directed toward a specific object, such as moods (Eagly and Chaiken 2007), are excluded from the definition. This premise also clarifies how consumer ambivalence is related to other consumption-relevant conflicts. For example, because consumer ambivalence is directed toward *one* object, choice conflicts are excluded from the definition, as they refer to not knowing how to choose one alternative over others when the alternatives are equally attractive in all essential respects (Tversky and Shafir 1992).

¹ A rich literature exists suggesting different asymmetries between positivity and negativity. For example, in studies of within-alternative conflict, evaluations of different attributes take different weights (Luce et al. 2003), implying that a positively evaluated attribute can compensate for negatively evaluated attributes, if it is given more weight in the final evaluation, or vice versa. In another stream of literature focusing on biases, a negativity bias has gained support in numerous studies. The most important principle of negativity bias is that the holistic evaluation of an object is more negative than the algebraic sum of positivity and negativity in the structure of the evaluation (Rozin and Royzman 2001), or in other words, evaluations tend to be affected more by negative than positive input (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994). On the other hand, when evaluative activation is low, a positivity offset tends to prevail, meaning that people tend to evaluate objects more positively than negatively (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994). While a more detailed review of these effects is outside of the scope of this manuscript, we encourage more discussion on the role of these asymmetries in ambivalence research.

Characteristics of different objects of ambivalence

While premise 2 states that ambivalence has only one object, it does not exclude the possibility of multiple ambivalences toward multiple objects in the same consumption episode because of the broad definition of “consumption episode” applied to this study (premise 3). After all, individuals can also evaluate different interrelated entities (Eagly and Chaiken 2007). For example, a consumer can be ambivalent toward a salesperson (Bush et al. 2015) while not being ambivalent toward the product that he/she is trying to sell.² A consumer may also evaluate the salesperson negatively and his/her offering positively (Otnes et al. 1997). Both of these objects could further be seen as attributes of the experience of buying products and services, which in this case would involve ambivalence. This is what we present as an “object hierarchy” in Fig. 1, where opposing evaluations of two objects (OBJ2 and OBJ3) constitute ambivalence in the evaluation of a higher-level object (in our example, the focal object OBJ1 would be the shopping experience, and OBJ2 and OBJ3 would be the salesperson and the offering). Further examination of object hierarchies is encouraged to advance this aspect of consumer ambivalence.

Another example of multiple objects is a situation in which a consumer evaluates an unhealthy dessert and piece of fruit jointly versus separately. This option is visualized in Fig. 1 (in this example, OBJ1 would be the dessert and OBJ4 would be the piece of fruit). Even though ambivalence occurs toward one object, the presence of another object may change the evaluation (Hsee et al. 1999), and therefore shape ambivalence toward the focal object. For example, the presence of fruit might make the dessert’s taste seem even better in comparison, but the fruit might also make the unhealthiness of the dessert more salient. Hence, the positive and negative attributes of the dessert could become more intense, and ambivalence would be increased. Ambivalence could also depend on how consumption objects are construed and contextual cues and the consumer’s motivations may lead to a particular categorization (Fazio 2007). For example, in the context of evaluating a dessert on its own, self-indulgence may be elicited, and the dessert would be categorized as a well-deserved tasty treat, implying a more positive overall evaluation of the dessert, and therefore, less ambivalence. On the other hand, if the dessert and the fruit are presented simultaneously, a weight loss motivation could be elicited; since the dessert is categorized as fattening, evaluation of the dessert would be more negative. Ambivalence would take place when these two categorizations are activated and the object does not clearly fall into only one of them.

The object of consumer ambivalence has also more direct implications for the amount and type of consumer ambivalence. Certain objects, such as condom purchase, inherently have a tendency of arousing high levels of ambivalence (Dahl et al.

² We would like to thank an anonymous reviewer for this excellent example.

2005). The object of ambivalence can also influence the amount of consumer ambivalence through the accessibility of object evaluations. Specifically, objects can be associated with object-evaluation associations of varying strength, and the strength of the association determines whether an evaluation is activated from memory (Fazio 1995). Furthermore, different objects might arouse different types of ambivalence (Conner and Sparks 2002). Accordingly, the papers in our sample were investigated to explore which objects of ambivalence were studied in each category of definitions (i.e., attitudinal ambivalence, mixed emotions, CCT). The objects can be categorized on multiple levels (Table 5); the highest levels concern the essential aspects of being human, such as morality and gender. The next level concerns political and societal issues, followed by rituals and relationships that represent social behavior. Definitions from CCT have predominated on these levels, which is natural because of their sociological background. All definition categories are found on the level of the behavior of individuals, represented by the acts of consumption and decision-making. Products, companies, brands, technologies, and countries have been studied as objects of ambivalence predominantly in terms of attitudinal ambivalence, whereas advertisements and experiences have been studied mostly in terms of mixed emotions. Whether this is simply an artifact of individual researchers' interests or a reflection of actual systematic differences in the relevance of attitudinal ambivalence, mixed emotions, or sociological ambivalence in terms of specific objects remains to be addressed by future research. However, because some research indicates that these differences may occur (Conner and Sparks 2002), researchers should pay attention to the implications of the object of ambivalence.

Premise 3: Consumer ambivalence occurs in consumption episodes.

This premise arises from the issues of simultaneity and sequentiality of the two valences, which is common for the definitions analyzed in this study. Although simultaneity technically means two things occurring at the same time (Jammer 2006), referring to specific consumption episodes, as visualized in Fig. 1, may be more appropriate in the consumer context. A consumption episode is defined in various and even contradictory ways in the literature. According to one view, it refers to a set of items that belong to the same event and occur in temporal proximity (Dhar and Simonson 1999). Accordingly, a consumption episode occurs along a continuum, as exemplified by a reference to having dinner: consuming three courses sequentially at the same restaurant constitutes a consumption episode, as opposed to dinner at the restaurant and dessert at home, which would constitute two episodes (Dhar and Simonson 1999). On the other hand, ordering and eating the food could also be seen as two separate episodes (Dubé and Menon 2000). Our approach to consumption episodes is inclusive, implying that depending on the research question, both the aforementioned definitions are

suitable. For example, if the research interest is in whether a consumer has an ambivalent evaluation of a restaurant during his or her first visit and whether this ambivalence influences his or her intention to return, then the consumption episode could be defined as the entire visit. However, if the focus of interest is the influence of ambivalence during eating the main course on the choice of ordering dessert, the consumption episode of interest would be eating the main course, and eating the dessert would be a separate consumption episode.

Our inclusive definition of the consumption episode implies that pre- and post-consumption can also be consumption episodes. For example, as visualized in Fig. 1, a researcher might define pre-consumption such as choosing a restaurant as one consumption episode, and the positive and negative evaluations occurring during pre-consumption could belong to T1 ambivalence. The actual consumption experience of going to the restaurant would set the temporal boundaries for the next consumption episode, and therefore, the evaluations occurring during the visit would constitute T2 ambivalence and post-consumption evaluations would constitute T3 ambivalence. These time points can be related such that the evaluations formed during T1 can be remembered in the next stages as pre-existing evaluations and operate as sources of positive, negative, or conflicting information, further influencing ambivalence in the next stages. Naturally, there can be multiple consumption episodes before, during, and after the actual act of consumption. For example, a wedding planning process consist of multiple pre-consumption episodes, such as buying a wedding dress, choosing flowers, and deciding on invitations (Otnes et al. 1997). We have visualized this example of what we term *sequential ambivalence* in Fig. 1. Furthermore, consumption episodes have a beginning and an end point, and are inherently processes. Accordingly, consumer ambivalence is a dynamic concept in that it can fluctuate during a consumption episode. The function of the consumption episode is therefore to give temporal boundaries to consumer ambivalence, because by defining the episode, a researcher is also inclined to define which evaluations belong to the same ambivalence and which ones belong to another. Instead of, or in addition to researcher-defined consumption episodes, study participants could be asked what they perceive to be a consumption episode in a given context. Future research should explore how consumer ambivalence is shaped by evaluations that are close in time but are perceived as being related to different consumption episodes, as opposed to evaluations that belong to the same consumption episode. We now turn to the characteristics of the consumption episode to shed light on its implications for the conceptualization and measurement of consumer ambivalence.

Characteristics of the consumption episode

Depending on the situational contingencies of the consumption episode, the amount and relative importance of different

Table 5 Objects of ambivalence and corresponding ambivalence types in existing consumer research

Category	Definition of ambivalence*			Examples of objects	Sources (examples)
	ATT	MIX	CCT		
Morality			x	Morality	Wicks et al. (2007)
Gender			x	Gender	Goulding and Saren (2009)
Political/ societal issues	x		x	Presidential candidates The Soviet regime	Jewell et al. (2002) Keller (2005)
Relationships			x	Relationships with others Being a target of teasing	Heisley and Cours (2007a, 2007b) Wooten (2006)
Rituals		x		Brand relationships	Fournier and Alvarez (2013)
		x		Death rituals	Darmody and Bonsu (2007)
Decisions			x	The trick-or-treating ritual	McKechnie and Tynan (2008)
	x			Replacement decisions	Roster and Richins (2009)
Consumption			x	Decision to consider cadaveric organ donation	Lai et al. (2005)
	x			Food consumption	Olsen et al. (2005)
			x	Technology consumption Consumer practices Using Facebook	Buchanan-Oliver and Cruz (2011) Connolly and Prothero (2008) Anderson et al. (2014)
		x		Prospective consumption Shopping situations	Bee and Madrigal (2013) Penz and Hogg (2011)
Technology	x			Technology	Ekici (2004); Davies (2014)
Products			x	Mechanical heart	Lai (2012)
	x			Green products Food products	Chang (2011) Cornil et al. (2014)
		x		Branded products	Mileti et al. (2013)
Advertising / marketing communication	x	x	x	Advertisements	Johnson and Grier (2012); Lorenzon and Russell (2012) Kramer et al. (2008) Ursavas and Hesapci-Sanaktekin (2013)
Experiences		x	x	Mixed emotions appeals Corporate sponsorship of local community events	Hong and Lee (2010) Weinberger and Wallendorf (2012)
		x	x	Watching a film Goal pursuit experiences The experience of nostalgia	McGraw and Larsen (2008) Mukherjee et al. (2012) Higson (2014)
Companies	x			Online seller/vendor	Moody et al. (2014)
Multiple objects		x		Company	Schmalz and Orth (2012)
		x	x	Multiple objects related to: Wedding planning, Colonialism Motherhood Nationhood	Nelson and Otnes (2005) Otnes et al. (1997) Bonsu (2009) VOICE Group (2010) Varman and Belk (2009)
Countries	x			Countries (of origin)	Russell et al. (2011)
Brands	x			Brands	Pang and Keh (2011)

*ATT = attitudinal ambivalence; MIX = mixed emotions; CCT = definitions in CCT

types of ambivalence, as well as the most appropriate measures, may vary. The episode can activate pre-existing evaluative tendencies and goals and provide new input to pre-existing evaluations as well as standards against which the object is judged; new evaluative responses are then generated (Eagly and Chaiken 2007). For example, a person with a

strong pre-existing positive attitude toward eating meat can become ambivalent while having dinner with vegan colleagues who can share new information about the problems involved in eating meat.

The characteristics of the consumption episode have implications for the successful measurement of ambivalence. When

measuring objective ambivalence, separate positivity and negativity scores are obtained, and a formula is used to calculate ambivalence based on such scores (Priester and Petty 1996). Such measurements are often obtained without reference to the consumption episode, which is defensible at least in the case of attitudinal ambivalence because attitudes are relatively enduring (Cacioppo and Berntson 1994). However, because a consumption episode can generate new, potentially conflicting evaluations, the consumption episode of interest should be clear to the participants whose ambivalence is being measured. While self-reported positive and negative evaluations measured after a consumption episode might be enough for many purposes, continuous measurements of ambivalence are encouraged for three main reasons. First, retrospective measures may not be accurate, especially in the case of emotions (Robinson and Clore 2002), potentially because individuals cannot always remember their emotions (Thomas and Diener 1990). As a solution, measures in which participants indicate their positive and negative emotions throughout an episode by pushing buttons (Larsen and McGraw 2011) or by moving a cursor (Larsen et al. 2009) have been developed. Second, self-reports may be biased; third, they do not capture the unfolding of ambivalence (Schneider et al. 2015). The last point is especially important because positive and negative evaluations can occur sequentially during a consumption episode. To address these issues, mouse movements have been used to capture ambivalence in real time; however, they correlate more with subjective than objective ambivalence (Schneider et al. 2015), and it remains a question for future research why this might be the case.

Whether objective ambivalence turns into subjective ambivalence is contingent upon the characteristics of the consumption episode. For subjective ambivalence to take place in a consumption episode, both the positive and negative evaluations need to be accessible (Newby-Clark et al. 2002). The situation (i.e., the consumption episode) can influence the accessibility of attitudes (Eagly and Chaiken 2007). Hence, especially if one is interested in measuring subjective ambivalence, choosing a consumption episode in which both positive and negative components are likely to be accessible is important. An example is when commitment to one side of an issue is necessary, such as when a choice needs to be made, although some uncertainty about its consequences exists (van Harreveld et al. 2009). While self-reports are the most obvious measure of subjective experiences, they may be problematic for reasons already discussed pertaining to objective ambivalence. As a solution, modern technology enables promising solutions to measure the experience of ambivalence through side-to-side movements on balance boards (Schneider et al. 2013) or mouse movements (Schneider et al. 2015).

Contextualizing consumer ambivalence

Thus far, three key premises of consumer ambivalence have been developed and discussed. Because the aim of this study is to conceptualize *consumer* ambivalence instead of a more general ambivalence, in this final section, we will contextualize the definition within the field of consumer research. In light of existing research, both the micro (internal) and macro (socio-cultural) contexts of the consumer are outlined, and how consumer ambivalence is shaped by these contexts is discussed.

The internal context of consumption refers to the factors inherent in the consumer that can shape ambivalence. In Fig. 1 we demonstrate how the internal context belongs to the same space as consumer ambivalence, that is, the area of consumer psychology. Personality is an important part of the internal context. For example, need for cognition, which refers to the tendency to engage in and enjoy effortful cognitive activities (Petty et al. 2009), can decrease ambivalence, whereas personal fear of invalidity, which refers to concern with error or the consequences of decisions, can increase ambivalence; however, these results hold only for highly involved individuals (Thompson and Zanna 1995). Furthermore, the relationship between objective and subjective ambivalence is strongest for individuals with a high preference for consistency (Newby-Clark et al. 2002). In addition, the individual's consumption-related goals can elicit ambivalence. For example, a dieter might have positive emotions toward food because of its taste, but also negative emotions because of its calories (Stroebe et al. 2013). Hence, a conflict between a short-term goal and a long-term one leads to both positive and negative emotions toward food during a consumption episode (i.e., consumer ambivalence).

By defining consumer ambivalence as internal to the consumer, this study advocates a psychological approach to ambivalence. However, psychological ambivalence occurs within a broader social and cultural context to which individuals belong (Hillcoat-Nallétamby and Phillips 2011). We have visualized this context as external to consumer psychology in Fig. 1. As the CCT and sociology literatures suggest, conflicting psychological states can be responses to conflicts in social structures, which are captured by sociological ambivalence (Merton and Barber 1976); however, the manifestation of ambivalence is on the level of the individual (Hillcoat-Nallétamby and Phillips 2011). For example, mothers-to-be come across varying ambivalent experiences during their role transition (VOICE Group 2010). Second, consumer ambivalence takes place in the cultural context of consumption, arising from "conflict among values, norms, traditions, and practices of different cultures not found within the same society" (Nelson and Otnes 2005, p. 89–90). Such cultural ambivalence does not need to be tied to national culture. For example, the experience of nostalgia can involve ambivalence because a

person perceives the values of the past as better than those of the present (Higson 2014). Finally, the social and cultural contexts are intertwined. For example, a subculture can become the site for conflicting norms, as in the case of the gothic subculture, in which traditional gender norms are challenged (Goulding and Saren 2009).

Conclusions

The aim of this study was to achieve an improved conceptualization of consumer ambivalence. As a result of an analysis of existing definitions, the formulation of three key premises, and the contextualization of consumer ambivalence, we have arrived at the following definition: *Consumer ambivalence is a structural property of any evaluative psychological concept to which two valences can be assigned; it occurs toward one clearly specified object during a consumption episode and within the internal and socio-cultural contexts of consumption.* Because the definition presents consumer ambivalence as a framework within which a number of evaluative concepts can be studied, it is inclusive enough to speak to a wide audience of consumer researchers, yet sufficiently narrow to avoid conceptual vagueness. We advocate this approach because if ambivalence were defined as an independent concept of its own, its use would be unnecessarily restricted. Our definition enables exploring consumer ambivalence on a large scale, which is important given the prominence of ambivalence (Fazio 2007). By capturing more of the true complexity of consumer ambivalence, our definition contributes to existing conceptualizations, especially to the pioneering work of Otnes et al. (1997). Yet, while developing the definition into this inclusive direction, we keep many elements of the existing definitions, and hence, enable future research to build on the existing work with increased precision.

In our reformulation of consumer ambivalence, we have paid special attention to the issue of conceptual vagueness in the existing definitions. One major source of vagueness is the temporal scope of ambivalence, which we resolved through the concept of consumption episodes (premise 3). Empirical testability of concepts requires conceptual precision (Strunz 2012), and we were accordingly able to provide guidelines for when different types of measures are most suitable. In addition, by clarifying the meaning of simultaneous and sequential ambivalence (premise 3), we enable more precise consideration of ambivalence over time, which is important because consumer behavior often involves different processes that extend over time (such as decision-making processes or buying processes). In a similar vein, by addressing vagueness around the valence component of ambivalence (premise 1), we have been able to resolve conceptual and methodological confusion around the interchangeable use of ambivalence and mixed emotions. We therefore remove some vagueness from the existing definitions by identifying the valence component as

positivity and negativity, instead of “mixed or multiple emotions” (Otnes et al. 1997, p. 82–83). We believe that appreciating the differences between ambivalence and mixed emotions enables more precise theorizing and measurement of both concepts in future consumer research. Finally, through a more elaborate consideration of ambivalence objects (premise 2), we separate consumer ambivalence from other consumption-related conflicts, and demonstrate the thus-far neglected relevance of the object in terms of understanding consumer ambivalence. Consequently, we demonstrate multiple avenues for future research concerning consumer ambivalence towards different objects.

Finally, we have addressed the problem of definition through antecedents, which makes the empirical testing of the theoretical linkages between concepts and their antecedents challenging (MacKenzie 2003), and therefore inhibits theory development around consumer ambivalence. Through a precise definition of the psychological core of ambivalence, as well as its socio-cultural context, we synthesize the seemingly separate streams of consumer research, CCT and consumer psychology, whose conceptualizations of ambivalence still remain unnecessarily isolated from one another despite previous attempts at synthesizing them (e.g., Otnes et al. 1997). The different conceptual conversations allow consumer researchers to cross-fertilize ideas, and thus support theoretical innovation and achievement (Arnould and Thompson 2005). Hence, we believe that our definition will appeal to a wide audience of consumer researchers, and consequently will advance consumer research from a holistic perspective.

Although the sample of articles analyzed in this study was the result of a selective exclusion process, no reason exists to believe that this sample is not a representative and comprehensive body of ambivalence-related consumer research. Furthermore, evaluation criteria other than those used here could have been used for the definitions. Nevertheless, the chosen criteria show the major challenges in existing definitions of ambivalence in consumer research, and thus serve as a strong basis for critical evaluation. We hope that consumer researchers will find our suggestions thought-provoking and will be inspired to further evaluate and develop the concept of consumer ambivalence.

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